

India and Silicon Valley, for support in defining, fabricating, and marketing chipsets and aid startups to access free tools, IP licenses, and potential investment. We encourage partnerships and acquisitions if they align with semiconductor companies' business goals. We also incentivise attracting talent and startups to this domain and propose support for establishing design centres, innovation hubs, and microfabs.

What is the impact you foresee that these startups are going to create in this growing industry?

The semiconductor industry is all about designing and fabricating new chips. All industries utilise these chips and build embedded systems around the chips for various applications including modems, phones, cars, laptops, and routers. Most consumers of Semicon are automotive, telecom, smartphones, smart devices, space, and industrial applications. In our forecasts, we prioritised our cohort sectors to those developing chips for futuristic AI, IoT, and automotive and telecom industries. These sectors are rapidly growing in India, and their consumption is expected to rise significantly. To meet this demand, we aim to have indigenous chipsets. We prefer anyone innovating in these areas and those involved in chip building for other industries.

What role do incubators play in determining a startup's success?

Historically, successful companies might have taken 10 to 15 years to achieve their current level of success. However, with the assistance of incubators, we can significantly reduce this timeframe by 50%. A company that previously took 15 years to build can now achieve the same level of success in 6 to 7 years with the support of incubators. Incubators offer startups various

avenues for growth in investment, mentorship, corporate customers, partnerships, international market expansion, or assistance setting up their plants and factories. This catalytic role is not limited to a single incubator; it extends across the country, reducing the time required for startups to succeed. The incubation model we have implemented has proven successful, not just in India but also overseas.

What are your selection criteria for patronising a startup in the semiconductor sector?

Our screening process focuses on several key aspects, such as the founder's experience, the roadmap they envision, the problem they aim to solve, the chosen solution, and the market size for that problem. While screening around 400 to 500 companies, we extract this information from the founders' pitches. We also consider factors like any intellectual property (IP), patents, or research backing the startup. Recognition through research papers by reputable entities in the semiconductor industry adds value to the selection process. Researchers with PhD credentials and patents initiate some startups in our semiconductor cohort. We actively support these startups in building their products and companies. We also have semiconductor startups with backing from the United States, further enriching the diversity of our cohort.

Is there a particular team that oversees the selection process, and what are their qualifications?

In the selection process, we ensure a panel with a deep understanding of the semiconductor industry. Venkata Simhadri, the ex-CEO of MosChip, and M Srinivasa Rao, CEO T-Hub, and myself take an active part in selection. We've built a diverse mentor pool, including

individuals from research bodies and corporations, who join us on a need basis for the panel-based screening of startups.

How do you generate funding for these startups?

We assist these companies with state and central government grants, encourage participation in PLI and DLI schemes, and connect them with mentors from this sector. Working closely with the government of Telangana, we advocate for funding by educating and collaborating with investors, including angels and VCs. We have synergies with numerous investors, investor groups, and VC firms, and provide them with a curated list of matured companies across various sectors, who evaluate our startups. If aligned with their investment criteria, many invest in these companies at the HNI (high net worth individuals), angel, or VC stages.

What is your approach to managing all this funding for different sectors?

We are a facilitating platform. When startups approach us seeking investment, we connect them with potential investors. Conversely, when investors approach us, looking to connect with startups for investment opportunities, we also facilitate those connections. Alongside this role, we have an investment desk—a team continuously monitoring the investment landscape in the country and sector-specific investments. They engage in an ongoing iterative cycle of educating individuals relevant to these sectors about our companies, their stage, and potential investment opportunities. We organise various events involving investors. For example, sector-based conclaves where investors in a specific sector advise young companies on raising investments. They also share their experiences of securing investments while managing their companies. **EFY**